Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Services in Toronto: Methodology

November 6, 2026

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Research Methodology

This study will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto childcare Centre learn about, access, and use or do not use the family support services that the Centre offers or refers them to. Qualitative research explores a central phenomenon in depth through detailed accounts from a small number of participants (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Depth matters because the central question concerns a process, namely how a family moves from first hearing about a service such as the fee subsidy to deciding whether to apply. A count of applications might show that some families never applied, yet it could not show what they understood, who explained the rules, or where they stopped. Only parents' own accounts can reconstruct that sequence, which is why the study relies on in-depth interviews.

Context is the second reason for this approach. Qualitative researchers attend closely to the context in which participants' experiences take place (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, that context consists of how the Centre shared information and in what language, which referrals staff made, and what an application required. These circumstances differ even within one Centre, since a parent who works evening shifts or reads English with difficulty meets the same notice and form under different conditions. Because context is carried in what parents report, it does not depend on where the interview takes place, so a Zoom or telephone interview can capture it as fully as a meeting at the Centre.

The third reason is meaning-making. Mwita (2022) describes qualitative research as concerned with how people make meaning of their social realities, which matters for families who meet services designed and explained largely from the provider's side. A term such as eligibility or waitlist may mean one thing to an educator and another to a parent still learning Toronto's childcare system. If the study defined barriers and help in advance, it would record the researcher's categories in place of the families' own. Open-ended questions will instead let

parents explain what helped, what confused them, and what a service meant for their family, so the findings reflect how families themselves interpret access.

Research Design

The study will follow a qualitative descriptive design. Sandelowski (2000) describes qualitative description as a comprehensive summary of events in the everyday language of the people who experienced them, with interpretation that stays close to the data. In keeping with this low level of inference, the interviews will be analyzed with thematic analysis at the semantic level, which codes what participants explicitly say (Braun & Clarke, 2022). Design and analysis therefore work together to keep the findings anchored in parents' own accounts.

The main reason for this design is that it makes the study practical to carry out in a way that answers the research question. Because qualitative description reports events in participants' own terms (Sandelowski, 2000), the interview protocol can follow the order in which a family meets a service, from hearing about it and working out its requirements to seeking help and deciding whether to use it. The findings can be organized along the same sequence, so each stage answers part of the sub-questions about what helped or limited families and how the Centre responded. Hall and Liebenberg (2024) add that the design suits studies needing information directly from the people affected but working with limited time and resources. With four interviews due between Weeks 2 and 4 and a findings report in Week 7, a design that needs only one round of interviews keeps the project feasible. Findings close to participants' words can also inform practice (Villamin et al., 2025), showing educators which explanations and referrals parents found useful.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

Four newcomer parents or primary caregivers will take part in the study. In this study, a newcomer family is an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have

arrived in Canada within the past five years, (c) have a child enrolled at the study Centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the Centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto childcare fee subsidy, EarlyON programs, or settlement services, and (e) be able to take part in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria select parents with recent, first-hand experience of the services the research question asks about. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they used a service, because the central question concerns both, and a parent who decided against applying can describe that decision as fully as one who applied. Families will not be grouped as users and non-users or compared, since four participants cannot support comparisons between groups.

Three groups will be excluded. Families I worked with directly during my field placement will not be invited, because a parent who knows me as their child's educator may find it hard to decline or to criticize the Centre (Villamin et al., 2025). Centre staff and their family members will be excluded, since their employment could create pressure to participate or to speak favorably. Parents who already hold Canadian citizenship will also be excluded. Citizenship removes the status-based eligibility rules that newcomers may face when applying for services, and it usually reflects a longer settlement period than this study explores. Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, and people on work or study permits will be eligible, because each status carries different eligibility conditions that shape families' experiences.

Screening will ask only when the parent arrived in Canada and whether they hold citizenship. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), so broader questions about status could discourage these families from taking part.

Recruitment Setting

Participants will be recruited from a licensed childcare Centre in the Parkdale neighborhood of west Toronto, where I completed my field placement. To protect families' privacy, the Centre will not be named in this proposal or in any report. The Centre was chosen

because it already shares information about family support services and refers families to them, so its parents have the experiences the research question addresses. Toronto's service plan also names childcare settings as access points and identifies tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), which makes one Centre a meaningful site for seeing how city services reach newcomer families. My placement provides the access needed to recruit within the course timeline, which is also why families I worked with are excluded.

Recruitment Methods

Before recruitment begins, I will obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the Centre director, and no family will be contacted until both are in place. I will then prepare a one-page flyer and a letter of information in plain English, translated into Mandarin and other languages common at the Centre. The materials will state the purpose of the study, the total time of about 60 to 75 minutes in one meeting, the voluntary nature of participation, the $25 gift card, and how to reach me, so that parents can decide with full information.

The $25 gift card recognizes each parent's time, yet any incentive raises the question of whether it could pressure someone to participate. The Tri-Council Policy Statement asks researchers to weigh incentives against participants' economic circumstances so they do not become undue inducements (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022), and Head (2009) discusses how payment in qualitative research can acknowledge participants' time while raising concerns about undue influence on consent. A modest amount for 60 to 75 minutes is unlikely to override a family's judgment, especially when it is not tied to completing the interview. Parents will therefore receive the card at the start of the meeting and keep it if they withdraw, and the Research Ethics Board will review the amount, so the card remains an acknowledgement and not an inducement.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and family cubbies, and staff will not approach families in person. As in Hardware et al. (2026),

someone other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation to avoid a conflict of interest. Because a notice from the director may still read as a request from the Centre, the flyer will state that the Centre will not know who takes part and that the decision will not affect any child's care. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, those people are newcomer parents to whom the Centre has given information about, or a referral to, a family support service, since only they can describe the process the research question asks about. The sample will also be a convenience sample of willing and available parents at a Centre I can already reach (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The purposive criteria therefore determine who is eligible, while convenience determines where eligible parents will be found.

Participant Selection. Interested parents will contact me directly by email, phone, or text, and I will screen each one in a 10-minute call against the inclusion and exclusion criteria. The Centre will play no part in screening or selection, so it will not learn who responded. Eligible parents will receive the letter of information and consent form in their preferred language and will have at least 48 hours to decide. The first four eligible parents who agree will form the sample, with one adult per family, and others will be offered a place on a waitlist and invited in turn if a participant withdraws before the interview. Selection in order of contact is practical for a four-person study, but because it may favor parents who respond quickly, this limitation will be noted in the findings.

Sample Size. The study will include four participants. Qualitative studies commonly involve about four to eight participants so that the researcher can explore each person's experience in detail (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019), and four also meets the course requirement for individual projects. The findings will therefore describe these four families' experiences in depth and will not be generalized to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

Data will be collected through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews. The interview is the data collection method, and an interview protocol is the tool that guides it. The protocol will list open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and its flexible order will let me ask for more detail when a parent raises something unexpected. Individual interviews suit this study better than focus groups, since income and subsidy eligibility are sensitive topics and families at one Centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, the protocol will be piloted with one newcomer parent from outside the study to check its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will take part in one meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes at a time the family chooses. Families may meet in a private room at the Centre outside drop-off and pick-up times, on Zoom, or by phone, and those who join online may turn off their camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will interview Mandarin-speaking parents myself, and for other languages a trained interpreter who signs a confidentiality agreement will join, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will go through the letter of information in the parent's language and answer any questions. The parent will then sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent and will receive the $25 gift card at this point.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** The parent will record years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the services the Centre shared or referred. The form will not ask about immigration category or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With the parent's permission, the interview will be audio recorded. Its questions will follow the steps a family takes toward a service, asking how parents learned about it, what they understood about eligibility and applying, and who helped them, whether an educator, a settlement worker, or a relative. Parents will then explain what led them to use or not use the service. The

final questions invite them to describe whether they could raise needs related to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would suggest the Centre change. At the end, each parent will receive a list of community supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Participation will be voluntary throughout. Parents may skip any question or stop the interview at any time and will keep the gift card, and they may withdraw their data within one week after the interview, before coding begins, without any effect on their child's care. Names will be replaced with pseudonyms, and recordings and transcripts will be kept in encrypted, password-protected files stored apart from the consent forms. Only I will hold the list that links pseudonyms to names. Because a small sample from one Centre can make people identifiable, reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language, and any quotation that could identify a family will be changed or left out (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Ethics approval, the director's permission, translation of materials, and a pilot of the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Distribution of the invitation, one reminder if needed, screening, consent, and scheduling of interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Interviews begin in Week 2, with at least three of four (75%) completed by the end of Week 3 and each transcribed soon after
Week 4	Complete data collection	Final interview and the start of initial coding
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Summary of preliminary findings submitted
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Semantic thematic analysis completed and the findings report submitted by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Findings reviewed and refined in response to feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Draft of the presentation completed
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Presentation and final report revised
Week 14	Final submission	Final report submitted

The schedule depends on ethics approval being in place before the term begins, because recruitment starts in Week 1 and interviews start in Week 2. Transcribing each interview soon after it ends allows coding to begin in Week 4, so preliminary findings can be submitted in Week 5. Decisions, changes, and challenges will be recorded in a reflexive journal throughout the study.

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